

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Lawn to Native Meadow Garden

Replace a patch of lawn with native flowers and grasses that bloom from spring to frost and never need mowing.

25 × 10 FEET · 96 PLANTS · FULL SUN · AVERAGE SOIL

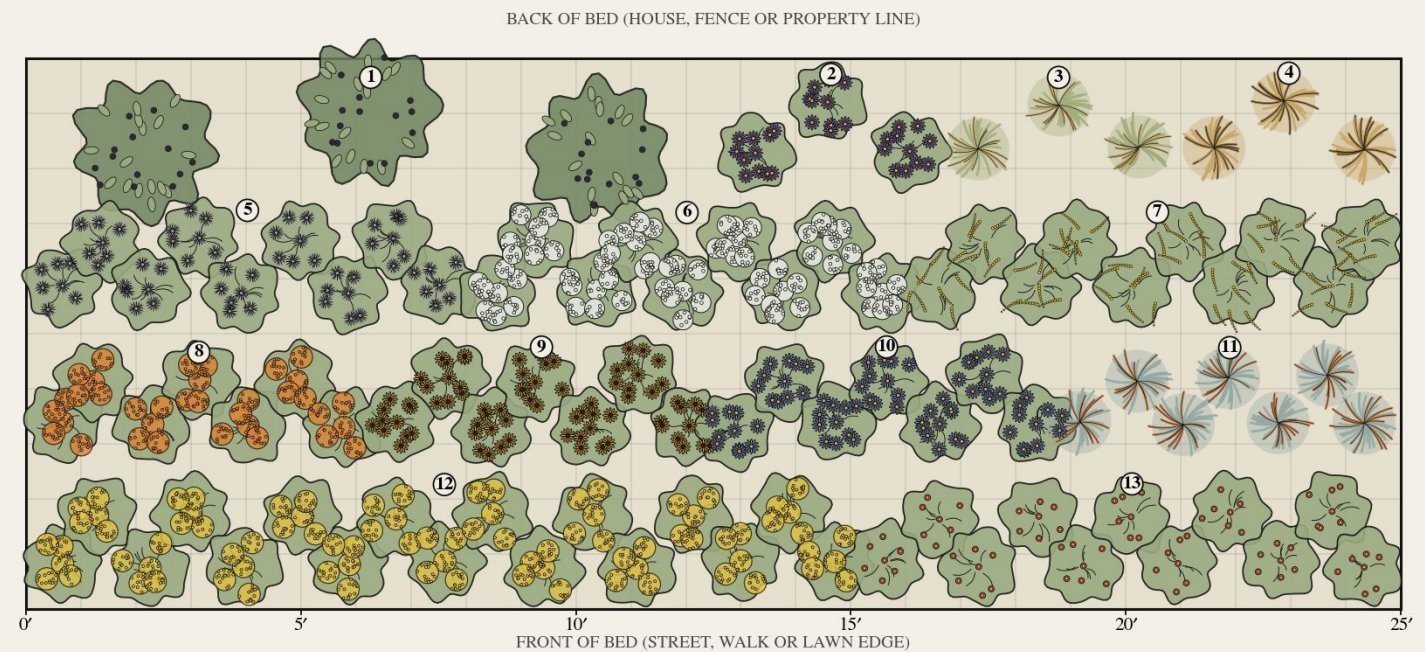


Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

This plan turns a rectangle of lawn into a bed of native flowers and grasses. Rebate programs call it conservation landscaping or native planting, and many of them pay homeowners back for doing it.

Everything here is native to Maryland. It blooms in waves: golden alexanders and columbine in spring, bergamot, butterfly weed and mountain mint in summer, then asters and grasses into October. Monarchs, bumblebees and goldfinches all use it.

Page 4 shows what the program pays and how this plan meets its rules. Page 5 is the plant list, laid out the way the application asks, plus the photo and step checklist.

Take the lawn out by smothering it with cardboard and mulch, or by cutting the sod. Don't start until your application is approved.

WHAT TO BUY

- ☐ 3
- Black chokeberry
- (1)
- ☐ 3
- New England aster
- (2)
- ☐ 3
- Switchgrass
- (3)
- ☐ 3
- Indian grass
- (4)
- ☐ 9
- Wild bergamot
- (5)
- ☐ 9
- Virginia mountain mint
- (6)
- ☐ 10
- Showy goldenrod
- (7)
- ☐ 7
- Butterfly weed
- (8)
- ☐ 7
- Black-eyed Susan
- (9)
- ☐ 7
- Smooth blue aster
- (10)
- ☐ 7
- Little bluestem
- (11)
- ☐ 17
- Golden alexanders
- (12)
- ☐ 11
- Wild columbine
- (13)

96 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

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MONTGOMERY COUNTY EDITION

HARDY IN ZONES 4-8 · PLAN NO. MD-09 · ORBITAL DESK LLC

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The Bed at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Black chokeberry

Aronia melanocarpa · 3-6 ft · Apr-May

Berries for birds in winter. Brilliant red fall color; very adaptable.

2. New England aster

Symphyotrichum novae-angliae · 3-6 ft · Aug-Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

3. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3-6 ft · Jul-Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

4. Indian grass

Sorghastrum nutans · 3-6 ft · Aug-Sep

Seeds for birds. Golden plumes in late summer.

5. Wild bergamot

Monarda fistulosa · 2-4 ft · Jul-Aug

Bumblebees and hummingbird moths. Tolerates drought once established.

6. Virginia mountain mint

Pycnanthemum virginianum · 2-3 ft · Jul-Sep

One of the best plants for pollinator variety. Minty leaves that deer often pass over (not deer-proof).

7. Showy goldenrod

Solidago speciosa · 2-4 ft · Aug-Oct

Hundreds of insect species. Clump-forming; doesn't run like Canada goldenrod. Goldenrod doesn't cause hay fever.

8. Butterfly weed

Asclepias tuberosa · 1-2.5 ft · Jun-Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Deep taproot; hates being moved. Great for dry, sandy spots.

9. Black-eyed Susan

Rudbeckia hirta · 1-3 ft · Jun-Sep

Many small native bees. Short-lived but reseeds freely.

10. Smooth blue aster

Symphyotrichum laeve · 2-4 ft · Sep-Oct

Late-season bees. Tidier than New England aster; good in dry beds.

11. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2-3 ft · Aug-Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

12. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1-3 ft · May-Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

13. Wild columbine

Aquilegia canadensis · 1-2 ft · Apr-Jun

Early hummingbirds. Thrives in rocky, thin soil.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Black chokeberry → Common ninebark
(*Physocarpus opulifolius*)

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What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Black chokeberry												
2. New England aster												
3. Switchgrass												
4. Indian grass												
5. Wild bergamot												
6. Virginia mountain mint												
7. Showy goldenrod												
8. Butterfly weed												
9. Black-eyed Susan												
10. Smooth blue aster												
11. Little bluestem												
12. Golden alexanders												
13. Wild columbine												

The Almanac: Looking After It

REMOVING THE LAWN

After approval, smother the grass with cardboard and 3-4 in of mulch for a few weeks, or cut the sod out. Call 811 before digging.

PLANTING

Plant in spring or early fall, straight through the mulch. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

THE FIRST YEAR

It'll look sparse. Pull weeds every two weeks; the plants fill in by year two.

MOWING

None. Cut the old stems to about a foot tall in late April and leave the stubs for nesting bees.

NEIGHBORS

A crisp edge (a stone border, a mown strip or a low fence) makes a meadow look intentional, and some programs ask for one in front yards.

KEEP IT WORKING

The program expects you to maintain the garden. Keep your receipts and before-and-after photos together in one folder.

SAFETY

Milkweed sap and lobelias are toxic if eaten (NC State Extension). Wear gloves when you cut milkweed, and keep pets and kids from chewing the plants.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

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Your Rebate Packet

Montgomery County · Rockville · Gaithersburg · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Program rate \$5/sq ft · at most \$1,250 for 250 sq ft, if approved

Approval isn't guaranteed, and the rebate can never be more than what you actually spend, with itemized receipts; labor you do yourself doesn't count. Cap: \$5,000 lifetime in Rockville and Gaithersburg; \$7,500 per home in the county program. Minimum size for this project: 250 sq ft. Programs covered: RainScapes (Montgomery County), Rockville RainScapes Rebate and Gaithersburg RainScapes Reward. Who can apply: Montgomery County, MD. Rockville and Gaithersburg residents apply to their city program. Takoma Park is excluded from the county program. Everyone else applies to the county.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	250 sq ft (Gaithersburg: 200 contiguous sq ft)	✓ 250 sq ft
Plants	At least 75% native; no invasives	✓ 100% native to Maryland (USDA)
Spacing	Full coverage in 1–2 years (12–18 in perennials, 36–48 in shrubs)	✓ Perennials 18 in, shrubs 48 in
The sketch	To scale, with species, container size, quantities and density	✓ Fig. 1 is to scale; the submission sheet has the rest
Mulch	Rockville 3–4 in; Gaithersburg 2 in; no plastic or fabric	✓ Listed on the shopping sheet

MEASURING THE AREA

The rebate is paid on the square feet of lawn you convert. Stake out the bed (25 × 10 ft = 250 sq ft), take your 'before' photos with the stakes in, and keep them. A curved edge is fine; keep the same area.

THE SKETCH

Fig. 1 on page 1 is drawn to scale with every plant placed. On a copy, sketch in your house, driveway and any trees near the bed, and write in the distances. That, plus the plant list on page 5, is the planting plan the application asks for.

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Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Black chokeberry	<i>Aronia melanocarpa</i>	3 gal	3	48 in	MD
2	New England aster	<i>Symphyotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	3	18 in	MD
3	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	3	18 in	MD
4	Indian grass	<i>Sorghastrum nutans</i>	Quart	3	18 in	MD
5	Wild bergamot	<i>Monarda fistulosa</i>	Quart	9	18 in	MD
6	Virginia mountain mint	<i>Pycnanthemum virginianum</i>	Quart	9	18 in	MD
7	Showy goldenrod	<i>Solidago speciosa</i>	Quart	10	18 in	MD
8	Butterfly weed	<i>Asclepias tuberosa</i>	Quart	7	18 in	MD
9	Black-eyed Susan	<i>Rudbeckia hirta</i>	Quart	7	18 in	MD
10	Smooth blue aster	<i>Symphyotrichum laeve</i>	Quart	7	18 in	MD
11	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	7	18 in	MD
12	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	17	18 in	MD
13	Wild columbine	<i>Aquilegia canadensis</i>	Quart	11	18 in	MD

96 plants · 25 × 10 ft = 250 sq ft · 100% native to Maryland (USDA PLANTS) · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 2.4 cubic yards at 3 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Rockville and Gaithersburg: apply online through the Chesapeake Bay Trust. Everyone else: apply through the county RainScapes portal.
- ☐ County program only: a RainScapes planner visits first; send your plan within 3 months of that visit.
- ☐ Send the pre-approval items: plant list, planting diagram, up to 5 site photos, and a perc test for rain gardens.
- ☐ Wait for written approval and sign the Property Owner Agreement. Don't buy or dig before approval.
- ☐ Call Miss Utility (811) at least 3 business days before digging.
- ☐ Install on time (12 months in the cities; 6 months after plan approval in the county).
- ☐ Upload itemized receipts (sales tax is deducted) and completion photos; a site visit may follow.
- ☐ Rebate check follows (2–3 weeks in the cities; 8–12 weeks in the county).

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The lawn before, with the bed staked out
- ☐ The bed after the grass is removed
- ☐ Planting day
- ☐ The finished bed from the street or house
- ☐ A close-up showing plant spacing

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

The approval letter, every itemized receipt (plants, mulch, compost, rented tools), your photos, and this packet.

SOURCES

cbrtrust.org Rockville RainScapes Rebate: Rain Garden and Conservation Landscaping guidelines, 7.1.26; Gaithersburg RainScapes Reward Application Instructions FY27, 7.2.26; montgomerycountymd.gov/propertycare/rainscapes (checked 10/1/26).

DISCLAIMER

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